

As I emphasized in Chapter 2 on the topic of life insurance, please do not confuse the statistical relationship between these factors and actual causality. We are not sure exactly what causes this relationship and whether other factors are at play that impact the link between wealth and longevity, or marital status and longevity. All we can say for certain is that mortality rates are lower among these groups of people. Once again, from a practical perspective, if you are a member of the groups identified as having more favorable mortality experience, you likely should plan for a much longer retirement compared to the average person in the population.

Even status has been linked with an increased life expectancy. Table 7.5 displays the results of a study that examined the impact on life expectancy of being nominated for a particular award versus actually winning it. The difference can mean as much as an extra four years of life.

TABLE 7.5 Status of a Long Life

# of Extra Years	Control Group
3.9	Win Academy Award versus being nominated
1.4	Win Science Nobel prize versus being nominated
2.8	Win Chemistry Nobel versus being nominated

Source: D. Redelmeier and S.M. Singh, *Annals of Internal Medicine*, 134(10):955; M.D. Rablen and A.J. Oswald, Warwick Economic Research Papers, January 2007.

Just as important as the wide variation in longevity estimates depending on the group in question, for any given group, it is virtually impossible to predict what these numbers will look like 10 or 20 years from now. Will some pharmaceutical company discover a drug that eliminates most cancers or heart disease, which will then add five to ten years of life? Or will the epidemic of adult obesity continue to erode public health and thus reduce longevity probabilities? Once again the experts can't answer these questions with any degree of accuracy; this is yet another aspect of what is called aggregate longevity risk.